Burning Down the House (Selections From)

By Steve Colman, Roger Bonair-Agard and Alix Olson

NOTE: This selection is from a collection of slam poetry and, as such, does not have stage directions or characters. Check with the regulations governing DUO for your state or tournament before performing.

INTRODUCTION

VOICE 1: *In some countries, poets face death;*
VOICE 2: *Here, in the United States they face apathy.*
VOICE 1: *So we welcome the opportunity to be able to share the words of these poets with you.*
VOICE 2: *Hopefully they will inspire, inflame, and maybe even provoke you to raise your voice!*
VOICE 1: *Through their words, we are lighting the match . . .*
VOICE 2: *Starting the fire and . . .*
TOGETHER: *Burning Down the House by*
VOICE 1: *Steve Colman,*
VOICE 2: *Roger Bonair-Agard*
VOICE 1: *and Alix Olson.*

EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Wanna Hear a Poem by Steve Colman

VOICE 1: I Wanna Hear a Poem
VOICE 2: I wanna learn something / I didn't know
VOICE 1: I wanna say "YES" at the end, / because I'm sick of saying "so?"
VOICE 2: **I wanna hear a poem** / about who you are / and what you think
VOICE 1: *Not a poem about my poem - cause I know who I am.*
VOICE 2: **I wanna hear a** / love poem a sad poem an I hate my dad poem
VOICE 1: a dream poem an I'm not what I seem poem
VOICE 2: an I need poem an I also bleed poem
VOICE 1: an I'm alone poem an I can't find my home poem
TOGETHER: I just wanna hear a poem!
VOICE 1: **I wanna hear a poem** about revolution
VOICE 2: *about fists raised high / and hips twisting in a rumble / like a rumba.*

VOICE 1: I wanna follow / the footsteps of Chè / and hear the truth / about the day /the CIA killed Lumumba.

VOICE 2: **I wanna hear a poem** about struggle

VOICE 1: *So that / when I open my mouth / I can step outside myself.*

VOICE 2: I wanna listen to no less / than the sounds of protest / in the factories / where workers sweat / and make Air Jordans / and Pro-Keds.

VOICE 1: Because / if you wanna take shots at people / target Phil Knight and Bill Gates

VOICE 2: contemplate / how they own the products / and they got the goods

VOICE 1: how they act like they care / but they're just Robnin' Hoods.

VOICE 2: And because every second matters

VOICE 1: I wanna hear long poems / and short poems / about time and its limits

VOICE 2: because it took less / than three minutes / to attack Abner Louima

VOICE 1: to frame Assata Shakur / and destroy Hiroshima

VOICE 2: to kill Eleanor Bumpers / and Anthony Baez

VOICE 1: to gun down Malcolm / with bullets / they bought from the Feds.

TOGETHER: I wanna hear a poem

VOICE 2: where ideas / kiss similes so deeply / that / metaphors get jealous,

VOICE 1: where the subject matters / so much / that adjectives start holding pro-noun rallies at city hall.

TOGETHER: *Because I wanna hear a poem*

VOICE 2: That attacks the status quo

VOICE 1: That attracts the claps / Of the cats with the / Phattest flows / That makes the crowd pass / The hat and pack my / Cap with a stack of dough

VOICE 2: I wanna guess / your favorite color / then craft rhyme schemes / out of thin air.

TOGETHER: I wanna hear a poem

VOICE 1: about / why the statute of limitations for rape / is only FIVE F****** YEARS!!!!

VOICE 2: **I wanna hear a poem**

VOICE 1: **I wanna feel a poem**

VOICE 2: **I wanna taste a poem**

TOGETHER: **I WANNA HEAR A POEM!!!**

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier (as poetry)
2010 National Qualifier (as poetry)

TRANSITION

VOICE 1: *You notice that Steve Colman never says . . . I want to READ a poem.*
VOICE 2: *That's because in the world poetry today, words are more than letters printed on a page.*
VOICE 1: *To TRULY engage in poetry requires both an "author" and an audience.*
VOICE 2: *Poems are to be heard, felt, . . even tasted.*
VOICE 1: *Robert Bonair-Agard began learning of the power of words as a child in trinidad*
VOICE 2: *There, black students learned to read using The Weusi Alfabeti (The Black Alphabet) by Kasisi Yusef Iman, which is illustrated with Pan-African themes.*
VOICE 1: *There are drawings and photographs of armed African revolutionaries, pictures of black students, and writings on Malcolm X.*
VOICE 2: *That memory inspired this poem: How Do we Spell Freedom? by Roger Bonair-Agard*

How Do We Spell Freedom? - The Weusi Alphabeti Method By Roger Bonair-Agard

I.

VOICE 1: In 1970 I learned my alphabet / for the very first time, / - knew it by heart in 1971.
VOICE 2: *A is for Africa / B is for Black / C is for culture and that's where it's at*
VOICE 1: my mother taught me that from the Weusi Alphabeti / at a time when A was for apples in a country that / grew mangoes / and X was for xylophone when I was learning / how to play the steelpan
VOICE 2: black wasn't popular / or even accepted then
VOICE 1: but I wore dashikis sent to me from Nigeria / super fly suits; sky blue with the elbow patches / sent to me from america / and sandals made by original rastafari before weed & revolution needed fertilizer to grow
VOICE 2: my mother rocked bright saffron saris / we were phat 20 years too early and a thousand miles removed / my mother preached hard work / knowledge and how not to take shit.

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VOICE 1: *D is for Defense / E is for Economics*

II.

VOICE 2: I wrote my first protest letter at the age of 3 / to my grandfather / for calling me in out the front yard / Spelling f*** you with an / f-o-r-k-U

VOICE 1: put it under his pillow in the hope / it would blow up and burn his ear off at night / wanted to get started on the revolution thing

VOICE 2: *F is for Freedom*

III.

VOICE 1: *G is for guns - we gotta get some* / Weusi said

VOICE 2: evolved into 1979 and a revolution with a changing face

TOGETHER: **bang bang boogie to the boogie / say up jump the boogie - let's rock - yuh don't stop*

VOICE 1: black folk and brand names became entwined

VOICE 2: we re-invented dance and made wheels roll / with a limp

VOICE 1: Cuba had just told America he was Africa in Angola

VOICE 2: *K is for kings / L is for Land - we got to get it back*

VOICE 1: so we lost Jamaica to the IMF / Grenada to the marines / and Panama to Nancy Regan

VOICE 2: jherri curls became high top fades, became gumbies, became cesars / as Michael Jackson moonwalked his way into a lighter shade of pale

VOICE 1: my mother sent me to america - she said

TOGETHER: *"Go fix that!"*

IV.

VOICE 2: *K is for Kidnap / S is for Slavery* / - Weusi explained

VOICE 1: cool became buttah became phat / we lost our focus and our way / just about the time / black folk outside the nation / discovered the dangers of pork

VOICE 2: so fat backs became phat blacks / pigtails became dreadlocks / and fades faded to bald / as Michael Jordan discovered the magic of a fadeaway jumper / and endorsements

VOICE 1: *X is for the niggah who's blind deaf and dumb / X him out* – Weusi said

VOICE 2: my mother told me I should re-write that / that X is for the nigga who needs to be re-educated

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VOICE 1: that a corporate job does not spell freedom / marry white don't mean racist flight
VOICE 2: a democratic vote is not a revolutionary act / and as long as there's a sweat shop in Jakarta
TOGETHER: there is no difference
VOICE 1: between Patrick Ewing and O.J. Simpson

V.
VOICE 2: *God gave Noah the rainbow sign / - said no more water; the fire next time*
VOICE 1: J is for James Baldwin – next time is now
VOICE 2: H is for Huey / N is for Nat Turner / T is for Tubman
VOICE 1: M is for Malcolm, Mandela, Marley & Martin got shot / two weeks after he told black folk to boycott Coca-Cola
VOICE 2: Jessie Jackson still scared of niggaz with a purpose.
VOICE 1: - and someone must learn to read the signs with me.

AWARD HISTORY

IL State Finalist (as poetry)

TRANSITION

VOICE 2: *Audre Lorde once said: There are no new ideas, there are only new ways of making them felt.*
VOICE 1: *With all the problems and questions and bewilderments and beautiful troubles of the world, poets have a wealth of ideas.*
VOICE 2: *Using words to bring feelings to those ideas is what Alix Olsen has done in "America's on Sale!"*
VOICE 1: *She says: "All aspects of our lives have the potential to be politicized: to be articulated, highlighted, crafted in such a way that allows us to see the power relations embedded within whatever it is–*
VOICE 2: *and every poem has the power to do that. . .*
TOGETHER: *America's on Sale! By Alix Olsen.*

America's on Sale! by Alix Olsen

VOICE 1: ATTENTION SHOPPERS!!!
VOICE 2: attention 9 to 5 folk, cell-phone masses, / the "up and coming" classes,

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VOICE 1: attention sports-utility, / plastic-surgery suburbanites, / viagra-popping, gucci-shopping urbanites

VOICE 2: attention george-clooney loonies, / promise-keeper sheep, / stockbroker sleep-walkers, / big investment talkers, / ricki lake-watchers,

VOICE 1: attention walmart congregation, / shop til you drop generation,

VOICE 2: ATTENTION NATION!

TOGETHER: AMERICA'S ON SALE!

VOICE 1: We've unstocked the welfare pantry / to restock the wall street gentry

VOICE 2: it's economically elementary, / because values don't pay

VOICE 1: yes, american dreams are on permanent layaway,

VOICE 2: (there was limited availability anyway)

VOICE 1: the statue's of liberty's being dismantled, / $10 a piece to sit on your mantle

VOICE 2: or hang on your wall / by the small somalian child / you bought from sally struthers

VOICE 1: sisters and brothers, it's now or never, / these deals won't last forever-

TOGETHER: AMERICA'S ON SALE!

VOICE 2: (restrictions may apply if you're black, gay or female).

VOICE 1: and shoppers, / global perspective is ninety-ninety percent off / cause most of the world don't count to us

VOICE 2: our ethic inventory's low / cause moral business has been slow,

VOICE 1: yes, the values-company is moving to mexico-- and

TOGETHER: ALL ETHICS MUST GO!

VOICE 2: it's a remote control america that's on sale / cause standing up for justice can't compare / to clicking through it from a lazy chair—

VOICE 1: Answer: jerry, montel, oprah

VOICE 2: Question: folks who really care . . . for $1,000,000,000!

VOICE 1: in this new mcveggie burger world order

VOICE 2: where national health care is / one-hundred percent off!!

VOICE 1: and medicare's in the 50% bin, / so you can buy . . . / half an operation / when

TOGETHER: AMERICA'S ON SALE!

VOICE 2: and there's a close-out bid to determine / which religion will win / all the neon flashing signs of sin

VOICE 1: the christian coalition is bidding high / shoppers, you ask

TOGETHER: WHY!

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VOICE 2: who needs a higher power when / you've got the purchasing power to corner and market / one human mold.
VOICE 1: That's right- Real Family Values are being UNDERSOLD!!
VOICE 2: and it's open hunting season for the NRA!
VOICE 1: There's a special oozie discount-- only today!
VOICE 2: Gun control?? We say—
VOICE 1: black bear, black man, blow em both away!
VOICE 2: and Guiliani welfare mamas / are on the auction block again, / we're closing out this country the way we began.
VOICE 1: so step up for our fastest selling commodity / no waiting lines for HIV, / condoms and needle-exchange are a hard to sell thing / (to the right wing)
VOICE 2: so if you're a druggie or a fag – / Rent-to-Own your own body bag NOW!
TOGEHER: WHILE AMERICA'S ON SALE!
VOICE 1: We're selling fast to the AT&T CEO, / he's stealing all utilities, / he doesn't pass go, / and collects $1,000,000 anyway,
VOICE 2: he's the monopoly winner / because he bought the whole board
VOICE 1: and we bought the whole game / now no price is the same! / cause inflation is up on the CEO ego / and power's deflated as far as you go:
VOICE 2: Cause Nike bought the revolution,
VOICE 1: and lawschools bought the constitution
VOICE 2: tommy hilfiger bought the red, white, and blue, / a flag shirt for fifty dollars, the one being burned is you!
VOICE 1: marlboro bought what it means to be a man,
VOICE 2: lexus equals power- so get it while you can.
VOICE 1: maybelline bought beauty,
VOICE 2: new york's buying rudy
VOICE 1: mastercard gold bought the national soul
VOICE 2: Broadway bought talent and called it CATS!
VOICE 1: the republicans bought out the democrats / they liquidated all asses in a fat white donkey sale-
VOICE 2: now it's buy one shmuck, get one shmuck free / in the capitalist party!
VOICE 1: and there's nothing left to get in the way / of a full blue-light blow-out
TOGETHER: of the U.S. of A!
VOICE 2: there's a no-nothing back guarantee, / a zero-year warranty, / when you buy this land of the free-tos, ruffles, lays..

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VOICE 1: this home of the braves, the chiefs, the reds, the slaves!
VOICE 2: so call 1-800- i-don't-care-about-shit
VOICE 1: or www.F*** ALL OF IT. / to receive your credit for the fate of our nation-
VOICE 2: (Call now! Interest is at an all-time low)
TOGETHER: BUY IT ALL WHILE YOU CAN!
VOICE 1: cause america's being downsized, citizens, / and
VOICE 2: you're . . .
VOICE 1: all . . .
VOICE 2: fired.

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier (as poetry)
2006 National Qualifier (as poetry)

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SOURCE INFORMATION FOR ALL POEMS

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AWARD HISTORY THIS SELECITON AS A DUO

2008 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier

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